

Pahankanuwa Sermon #17

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

*Asāre sāramatino, sāre cāsāradassino; Te sāraṃ nādhigacchanti,
micchāsāṅkappagocarā. Sārañca sārato ñatvā, asārañca asārato;
Te sāraṃ adhigacchanti, sammāsāṅkappagocarā.*

From:

Verses 11-12 from the Yamakavagga (Chapter of Pairs) of the
Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

A person can achieve real progress and development only if they possess enough inner strength to abandon what is essence-less and accept what is essential. The life of a person who has the attitude of seeing the essence-less as essential and the essential as essence-less is completely unsuccessful. It is because our ancient Sri Lankan ancestors possessed the noble principle of abandoning the essence-less the moment they saw the essential that the Dispensation of the Buddha (*Sambuḍu Sāsana*), brought to this island of Lanka by the Great Arahant Mahinda on a Poson Full Moon day like today, took deep root in this country. The two verses we have taken as our theme today express this valuable principle, which is also vital for the future of this Dispensation.

The occasion for preaching these two verses arose in connection with certain events in the lives of the chief disciples of this Dispensation, the Venerable Sāriputta and Moggallāna. After the two Venerables Sāriputta and Moggallāna joined this Buddha-dispensation, entered the community, and attained Arahantship, the Buddha gathered the assembly and conferred the positions of Chief Disciples upon these two Venerables. At that moment, a certain critical whispering and murmuring arose among the monks regarding how the Buddha

conferred these positions. They muttered that the Buddha had acted partially, like one who distributes food by looking at faces. If the positions of Chief Disciples were to be given, they should have been given to the Group of Five Monks (*Pañcavaggiya*) who were ordained first. Or else, they should have been chosen from the fifty-five monks led by Yasa, the clansman. Or else, from the thirty youths of the *Bhaddavaggiya* group. Or else, from the thousand monks led by Uruvela Kassapa. In this manner, when the monks were engaged in such talk about the Buddha, the Buddha asked, "What are you discussing, monks?" When the matter was explained, he said, "Monks, I do not confer positions by looking at faces. I confer positions based on the past aspirations and the strength of the perfections (*pāramī*) of each individual." He then described in great detail the past meritorious deeds and the past assurances (*vivaraṇa*) received by Venerable Aññā Koṇḍañña, Yasa the clansman, and others individually. Finally, he declared how the two Venerables Sāriputta and Moggallāna received the definite assurance to attain the position of Chief Disciples from the Buddha Anomadassī.

After all these accounts had been declared, the two Venerables Sāriputta and Moggallāna came before the Buddha, paid homage, and declared before the assembly how they had engaged in their quest for truth before coming to the Buddha. If we briefly mention that account, it is as follows. Most of you may have heard the valuable life story of these two. There were two Brahmin clans in Rajagaha called Upatissa and Kolita. In those prominent families, two meritorious youths, two young Brahmins, were born. They received the names Upatissa and Kolita. These families had been friends for a long time. Likewise, these two also became very close friends and began to do everything together. After completing their education in their youth, just as young people usually do, they also turned to amusements. They were accustomed to going annually to watch a certain public festival called the *Giragga Samajja* (the Mountain-Top Festival) held in Rajagaha. Just as today we have various shows, musical nights, and so forth, it must have been something like that—a festival held on a mountain peak.

Although this was a custom, one year, on one occasion, while watching the *Giragga Samajja* festival, their wisdom accumulated through saṃsāric journeys had matured and ripened. Because of this, they did not laugh at places where they usually laughed. They did not show excitement where they usually showed excitement. They did not give gifts where they usually gave gifts. They looked on as if disillusioned. When the two spoke to each other, they realized they shared the same thoughts. What was the thought? "There is nothing of value here. There is no essence (*sāra*). This is essence-less. These people who are dancing, playing music, and singing here will all face death (*marana*) before a hundred

years have passed. It is far more valuable for us to go in search of the path of liberation (*vimukti*) from this saṃsāra." Thus, they both agreed and discussed what to do next.

"Now, if we expect liberation, we must obtain ordination. Under whom shall we obtain ordination?" At that time in Rajagaha, a wanderer named Sañjaya was famous, having a large following. They decided they must go there and ordain. Sending back their carriages and special retinues, they, along with five hundred companions, received ordination under the wanderer Sañjaya. Because these two possessed extremely sharp wisdom, within a few days they mastered everything Sañjaya knew, everything he taught. Then they asked their teacher, "Venerable Sir, do you know anything beyond this?" When he replied, "No, this is all I know. I cannot tell you anything beyond this," they thought, "Then staying here is essence-less. We must search for the truth individually." They made an agreement: "If either of us discovers the path to liberation, or Nibbāna, he must inform the other." They then went to various places, met teachers, and began to discuss and ask questions. Not a single teacher was able to answer their questions, whereas these two were capable of answering those teachers' questions.

While some time passed in this way, the Buddha was residing in Rajagaha, having accepted the Veluvana monastery. One day, Venerable Assaji, one of the Group of Five Monks, was walking for alms. On that day, the wanderer Upatissa—whom we now know as Venerable Sāriputta—after having his meal at home, was setting out to go to the wanderer's monastery when he saw this Venerable monk. He thought, "I have never seen anyone like this before. I have never seen anyone with such peaceful faculties and such calm deportment. He must be an Arahant or one who has entered the path to Arahantship. It is not proper to speak to him right now while he is walking for alms." Following behind him, after the Venerable monk finished his alms-round and prepared to eat his meal, Upatissa prepared a suitable seat for him, offered water from his own water vessel, performed all the duties, and attended to him. After the monk had finished his meal, Upatissa asked, "Friend, who is your teacher? What is the Dhamma you follow? Your deportment is very pleasant. Your complexion and skin are extremely radiant." He then requested, "Please tell me that Dhamma."

Then Venerable Assaji very humbly expressed, "I am a newly ordained monk, one who has recently entered the order. I cannot preach a long sermon or explain it in detail." Then the wanderer Upatissa said, "My name is Upatissa. Even a little is enough for me. You do not need to say many words. I only want the meaning, the core essence. If you say just that much, I will understand." Thus, he made his request. It was on that occasion that Venerable Assaji recited a highly profound

verse—a valuable verse that presents the complete core, the fundamental doctrinal principle of the Dhamma of Dependent Arising (*Paṭiccasamuppāda*).

Ye dhammā hetuppabhavā,

tesaṃ hetuṃ tathāgato āha,

tesañca yo nirodho,

evaṃvādī mahāsamaṇo.

"Of those phenomena that arise from a cause, the Tathāgata has declared their cause; and also their cessation. Such is the doctrine of the Great Ascetic." This is the meaning of that verse.

This verse is so deep, and the wanderer's store of merit and wisdom so sharp, that upon hearing just the first two lines of the verse, he attained the fruit of Stream-entry (*sotāpatti-phala*). The moment he heard that whatever phenomena arise from a cause, their cause has been declared by the Tathāgata, he attained Stream-entry. Then, after the verse was completed, the wanderer Upatissa asked the Venerable monk, "Where does our Teacher reside?" When told it was at Veluvana monastery, he asked for the way there and said, "I have one more task to do. I have a friend, and we have promised each other that if we find the truth, the deathless, or Nibbāna, we would inform each other. I will fulfill that promise and come. You may proceed ahead, Venerable Sir." Sending Venerable Assaji ahead, the wanderer Upatissa went back to the wanderer's monastery. As he was going, his friend Kolita saw him from afar. Seeing him, Kolita thought, "Today, my friend has an unusually radiant appearance. He looks so joyful. Surely, he must have attained Nibbāna." When he asked for details, the wanderer Upatissa recited the verse in full, explaining, "I met such a Venerable monk." Upon the completion of that verse, the wanderer Kolita also was established in the fruit of Stream-entry.

Then the wanderer Kolita said, "Let us now go to meet the Buddha." However, because Upatissa was always someone who respected teachers, he thought of their teacher, Sañjaya the wanderer, under whom they had studied for a short time, and said, "Let us also go and tell this new news to our teacher. Perhaps upon hearing this verse, he might understand the Dhamma. If he cannot, at least he might go to see the Buddha." So they went in search of him.

Seeing them, the wanderer Sañjaya asked, "Well, my children, did you find the truth?" When they told him the news, he did not show much faith. After they had explained everything, he said, "Then you two go. I cannot go." When asked, "Why?" he replied, "Having been a teacher for so long, I cannot now become a

disciple, a pupil. To use a simile, it is like having been a water-jar and then becoming a ladle or a spoon." You all know that a water-jar gives water to others. But a spoon or a ladle merely takes water from it. That was the simile he used. "Having been like a water-jar before, how can I now become like a spoon? That would be a loss of face for me, so I cannot go." When they entreated him again, saying, "Do not say so, teacher! Such a supreme person, a Buddha, has now been born in the world; the Dhamma has arisen, the Sangha has arisen. This is a great opportunity," he asked again, "My children, are there more fools or wise people in this world?" Upatissa and Kolita replied, "Fools are indeed in the majority." "Then it does not matter. The fools will come to me, and the wise will go to the wise Ascetic Gotama," he said, rejecting their invitation.

After he said this, as these two were departing, a large portion of the wanderer Sañjaya's followers set out to go with them. Seeing this, it is recorded that Sañjaya, out of distress, vomited blood from his mouth. He felt such great grief.

So, that is the account we mentioned. However, the two Venerables Sāriputta and Moggallāna recounted this entire event to the Buddha in front of the Sangha on that occasion. Finally, they said, "Even though we made such an effort, our teacher, the wanderer Sañjaya, did not come."

Hearing this, the Buddha declared, "Such is the nature of the world. Because of his wrong view (*micchā-diṭṭhi*), because of his wrong ideas, that Sañjaya regarded the essence-less as essential and the essential as essence-less. Because of your wisdom and intelligence, you two understood the true core and attained the essence." Praising them, he uttered the two verses we mentioned earlier:

Asāre sāramatino,

sāre ca asāradassino,

te sāraṃ nādhigacchanti,

micchāsāṅkappagocarā.

Those who take the essence-less to be essential, and see the essential as essence-less, they never attain the true essence, being in the pasture of wrong intention. Thus he expressed one side, and then he expressed the other side:

Sārañca sārato ñatvā,

asārañca asārato,

te sāraṃ adhigacchanti,

sammāsaṅkappagocārā.

But those who understand the essential as essential, and the essence-less as essence-less, they, conducting their thoughts according to right intention, attain the true essence. This is the meaning of that verse.

These are two valuable verses containing extremely profound thoughts. From this story and these two verses, on a day like today, we can draw out many points regarding the Buddha's Dispensation and our own lives. Now, if we look particularly at the first verse, the best illustration is contained in the very story we told—the character of the wanderer Saṅjaya. His character is revealed by that first verse. Why? *Asāre sāramatino*—he took what was essence-less as essential. Next, he took what was essential as essence-less. Consequently, a valuable opportunity slipped away. What is said there is that he did not have the strength to see the Buddha because of being prey to wrong intentions. To explain this in more detail along with the meaning of the verse, when we think about why the wanderer Saṅjaya was reluctant to go to the Buddha, we can see what those essence-less things were.

He had the power of a following, he had gains and hospitality (*lābha-sakkāra*), he had fame and praise. These were the things that the wanderer Saṅjaya regarded as great. All of these are essence-less things. Yet, he took those essence-less things as essential. Although they were fools, he had a large following. He possessed the power of a great crowd. Furthermore, due to pride (*māna*), he thought, "I am a teacher; I cannot become a disciple now." These are foolish thoughts. Accordingly, wrong intentions, if we speak in terms of the Noble Eightfold Path, are thoughts of sensual desire (*kāma-vitakka*), thoughts of ill-will (*byāpāda-vitakka*), and thoughts of cruelty (*vihimsā-vitakka*), which you all must have read about many times. Feelings regarding sensual desires, then feelings of anger, feelings of harming. Once one submits to such thoughts, one is continuously dragged in that direction.

Thus, it is that view (*diṭṭhi*), that vision, and that attitude which is expressed in the first verse. Saṅjaya is a good illustration of this. If we think accordingly, this fact is true not only for that time but also for the present day. The majority of the world belongs to the group described above. Also, many people are easily dragged towards wrong view (*micchā-diṭṭhi*). They are very easily dragged towards wrong views. What is called essence-less is, in short, that which belongs to the side of wrong views. Indeed, although we call it wrong view, sometimes what appears most dangerous is the type of truth called "half-truth." Half-truth, dear devotees, is an incomplete truth that appears true at first glance. But when looked

at from within, it contains empty things, false and hollow things. There are various shortcomings in them.

There is an ancient term used in this Dispensation for that "half-truth": *mugga-sūpatā* (resembling mung-bean soup). *Mugga* means mung beans, and *sūpatā* means soup-like. You can imagine—when eating rice with mung-bean gravy, occasionally unboiled, hard beans are chewed. Sometimes it is mostly these unboiled beans that are present. It is just like that. That is to say, they are only half-cooked. The category of half-truth is also like that. Just as in those days, today too, "mung-bean soup" is very popular. A large number of people are attracted to mung-bean soup. If you look at society, you will see this. Such is the state of society.

Next, when thinking about wrong view (*micchā-diṭṭhi*), the Buddha has declared that of all the wrongs in this world, the greatest wrong, the supreme blame (*parama-vajja*), is wrong view (*micchā-diṭṭhi*). Why is that? He says this with reasons. A person might think, "Why, we have freedom of thought. What does it matter to others if we hold whatever view we want?" One can ask in this way. But the primary cause for the ruin of a person's life is wrong view (*micchā-diṭṭhi*). The Buddha demonstrated the danger of wrong view (*micchā-diṭṭhi*) to the monks on that occasion with a good illustration and a good simile.

First, he states the matter: "Monks, all the bodily actions, verbal actions, and mental actions of a person of wrong view conform to the very wrong view they have adopted. Whatever intention (*cetanā*), aspiration, goal, or activity they initiate, it all conforms to that wrong view. Next, what is their kammic result (*vipāka*) and danger (*ādīnava*)? Because of this, they will have to experience severe unwholesome results, undergo suffering and hardships, and experience unpleasant, disagreeable results." Then comes the simile: "Monks, just as when a seed of neem (*margosa*), a bitter melon seed, or a bitter gourd seed is planted in moist soil, all the earth-nutrients and water-moisture it draws in work only to produce a bitter fruit; it yields only a bitter fruit. In the same way, the entire course of action of a person who has adopted wrong view leads to bad results, undesirable results, unpleasant and disagreeable results."

He declares the opposite side: "Similarly, monks, all the bodily, verbal, and mental actions of a person of right view (*sammā-diṭṭhi*) are nourished according to that right view. Likewise, their intentions, aspirations, expectations, goals, and activities are all shaped according to that right view and ultimately yield good results and good benefits (*ānisaṃsa*)." The simile for this can be understood accordingly: "Monks, just as when a grape seed, a seed of hill paddy, or a sugarcane seed is planted in moist soil, all the earth-nutrients and water-

moisture it draws in yield only a sweet fruit. Just so is right view (*sammā-diṭṭhi*)." Thus, he pointed out the difference between the two.

So, according to this, we can understand that the majority of people in the world today are those who follow the "mung-bean gravy," or in other words, who are dragged along by wrong views. Next is the second verse. The best illustration for this—even if not specifically mentioned—you can easily think of: the lives of the two Venerables Sāriputta and Moggallāna. Their lives demonstrate this to us. Indeed, when speaking of the Chief Disciples of this Dispensation, we must all consider that, next to the Buddha, our examples to follow are the Chief Disciples. Indeed, they are exemplary. When looking at it from another angle, they possessed the strength to discard the essence-less and humbly accept the essential. Even during their lay life, this is shown to us on several occasions. The first occasion was mentioned in this very story. In youth, the occasions when anyone goes to enjoy themselves are those various shows, musical nights, and so forth. But once saṃsāric wisdom matures, there comes a time when one gets weary of them. We have stated in previous Dhamma sermons that this entire world is like a school with eight grades. The majority of the world stays on the side of gratification (*assāda*). The crowd running after the five cords of sensual pleasure is the largest. Then, at some point, through the maturing of wisdom and through experience, the danger (*ādīnava*)—the defective side in them—begins to appear. Once that is seen, one passes to the class of escape (*nissaraṇa*) by ordaining. Here too, after their wisdom matured, the things they previously thought were essential appeared as essence-less to both of them. There was no laughter as before, no joy. They sat looking downcast, disillusioned. While everyone else was dancing and enjoying themselves, because their wisdom had matured, this appeared to them as essence-less.

Likewise, the next step they took was to abandon all those resources and enter ordination. Even that ordination was not at the right place; it was under the wanderer named Saṅjaya. Even there, they did not just linger thinking, "This is my teacher." After learning whatever was to be learned there, they understood that there was no essence here, and they abandoned that as well. Next, they began to search for the truth. In their search, the best illustration of being drawn to the truly essential is seen when they met the Venerable monk and requested him: "I do not need many words. Tell me the real essence." When requested thus, the Venerable monk recited a verse that, though seemingly simple, showed the core meaning of the entire True Dhamma—the essence of the profound Dhamma of Dependent Arising (*paṭiccasamuppāda*). The wanderer Upatissa understood the truth from the first two lines of that verse, and the wanderer Kolita also understood it by hearing the same verse. Here we understand that even if we do not analyze that verse in detail, in brief—as the elder devotees among you must

know—there is a doctrine called Dependent Arising (*paṭiccasamuppāda*). Many people, when they observe precepts, keep reciting the twelve factors like *avijjā-paccayā saṅkhārā, saṅkhārā-paccayā viññāṇam*. But, dear devotees, this is not the core of Dependent Arising (*paṭiccasamuppāda*). The real core is what is said in that verse. What is it? "Whatever phenomena arise from a cause, their cause the Buddha has shown, and also their cessation." If we briefly state the fundamental principle shown there, it is mentioned elsewhere in the Dhamma:

Imasmim sati idaṃ hoti, imassuppādā idaṃ uppajjati.

Imasmim asati idaṃ na hoti, imassa nirodhā idaṃ nirujjhati.

"When this is, that is; with the arising of this, that arises. When this is not, that is not; with the cessation of this, that ceases."

That is a core principle, a thesis. Within it lies the essence of the entire Dhamma of Dependent Arising (*paṭiccasamuppāda*). Regarding the things that the world considers as a self, as eternal and permanent, the wonderful reality that the Buddhas bring to light is always hidden in the world due to the darkness of ignorance (*avijjā*). That is this wonderful causal relationship between one and another, which is called Dependent Arising (*paṭiccasamuppāda*). This is what is revealed by this verse.

Therefore, due to the sharp wisdom of the wanderer Upatissa, upon hearing just the first two lines, he realized the fruit of Stream-entry (*sotāpatti-phala*) through the path-knowledge of Stream-entry (*sotāpatti-magga-ñāṇa*). There too, we see the appreciation of the essential. From this, we can see that no matter how many essence-less things there are in the world that attract people, our effort should be to gradually abandon the essence-less within us and acquire the essential. There is no use in clinging to essence-less things for a long time. You all must have heard a saying in society about "the tradition of the bundle of hemp (*haṇamiṭi sampradāya*)"—being like the man who clung to the bundle of hemp.

There is a long story behind that too. Briefly, it is like this. The story underlying this proverb is somewhat humorous. Two friends left their village to travel from village to village in search of wealth. On their way, they first came to a village where hemp was easily available, so abundant that it was discarded. So both of them bound two bundles of hemp and went to the next village carrying them. When they arrived there, hemp thread was available in plenty. Then one friend said to the other, "Now, we are carrying this hemp to make hemp thread. Let us discard this hemp and take the hemp thread instead." The other friend said, "No, no, I have bound this bundle of hemp very well. I cannot throw it away. You do what you want." So, one friend took the hemp thread, while the other carried the

same old bundle of hemp. When they went to the next village, hemp cloth was available. There too, the wise friend said, "Now, we are carrying this hemp thread to make cloth. Let us discard this thread and take the hemp cloth instead." "No, I don't want that either. I will carry this which I have brought with such difficulty," said the other and carried it on.

In this way, they went from village to village. To make it short, in the next village there was cotton cloth. In the next village, iron. In the next, brass. In the next, silver. In the next, gold—discarded in plenty. So, of these two, the wise friend discarded his previous bundle of silver and tied up a bundle of gold. The other friend was still carrying the bundle of hemp. Clinging to the bundle of hemp, he was unwilling to let it go. Then these two returned to their village. When they returned, the family of the hemp-carrier grieved and lamented greatly, saying, "After all this time, is this what you carried and brought?" Whereas at the house of the one who brought the bundle of gold, all the children and family were highly pleased and rejoiced.

That is the story. I told it because you devotees like to hear stories. This proverb is very common in society, but some may not understand its meaning, so it is good to know. Why? Because the majority of people go in that direction. They grasp tightly onto essence-less things for the sake of the temporary comfort they offer. Now, why did the wanderer Sañjaya follow those things containing half-truths? Because the majority of people are attracted to them. If one can gather a following, if one can obtain gains and hospitality (*lābha-sakkāra*), that was regarded as the great thing. He did not attempt to realize the supreme essence of escape from this saṃsāric cycle, which is liberation, the primary purpose of the entire life, of ordination, or of renunciation (*nekkhamma*).

Thus, according to this, even when we think about the future of this Dispensation, we can understand that to preserve this Buddha-dispensation, we must understand its true essence, highlight that essence, and lead our lives accordingly. Indeed, the Buddha once declared to the Great Arahant Mahā Kassapa one reason that leads to the decline of the Dispensation. Indeed, after the passing away of the Buddha, it was Venerable Mahā Kassapa who was most enthusiastic about preserving the Dispensation. Perhaps as a reason for this, on one occasion the Buddha said to Venerable Mahā Kassapa: "Kassapa, this True Dhamma (*Saddhamma*) does not disappear until a counterfeit Dhamma (*Saddhamma-paṭirūpaka*) arises in the world." A counterfeit thing. The simile used is gold. When we speak of gold, we often use the word *raṇa* (gold). In ancient books, two terms are used: *ratraṇa* (refined gold) and *amuraṇa* (natural gold). Gold that is refined, processed, and prepared is called *ratraṇa*. Natural gold is gold in its natural state. It is called *jātarūpa*. Even that natural gold

disappears from the world not due to anything else, but due to the arising of a counterfeit natural gold. To use a modern term, when an "imitation" of a certain kind arises, natural gold disappears from the world. People are deceived, thinking it is natural gold. The Buddha declared that a similar thing happens to the True Dhamma.

Therefore, it is not through other religions of wrong view (*micchā-diṭṭhi*) that this Dispensation can be destroyed; it can be destroyed from within. Why? What are called "counterfeits of the True Dhamma" (*Saddhamma-paṭirūpaka*) are things that merely look like the True Dhamma. They are also just like that mung-bean soup. Many people are likely to be attracted to them. You devotees must be mindful of this when thinking about the future.

One must understand the true essence of the True Dhamma. What is the essence? A Buddha arises in the world to provide the solution through the path of liberation (*vimukti-magga*) to this saṃsāric problem, which no other teacher could resolve. It is to bring to light this saṃsāric liberation. In short, Nibbāna is the ultimate goal and the essence. This is shown in the Dhamma by the Buddha on one occasion in the *Mahāsāropama Sutta* using the simile of a Sal tree. Now, some people go and break off the leaves, twigs, and branches of a Sal tree, taking them as valuable things. Another takes the bark. Another takes the sapwood. But only a rare person takes the heartwood (*sāra*), the truly valuable thing. Similarly, in this Dispensation too, there is a distinction between the valuable and the valueless. Suppose someone becomes ordained, or turns to these activities. Then, gains and hospitality (*lābha-sakkāra*) flow in. These are like the leaves and branches. Next, like the bark, is virtue (*sīla*). That too is a great thing, better than the former. But that itself is not the essence. Beyond that is concentration (*samādhi*). Passing all these, next is the fruit of Arahantship (*arahatta-phala*), or Nibbāna—that liberation obtained through the realization of the paths and fruits (*magga-phala*). That alone is the core, the essence of this Dispensation.

Therefore, if any Dhamma sermon forgets that Nibbāna, puts Nibbāna aside, and emphasizes mundane goals that provide temporary relief... In the past, Dhamma preachers concluded all Dhamma sermons by pointing towards Nibbāna. But now, Dhamma sermons often end not with that, but with common, mundane goals. Many people also like that. Why? Because they think it is a great thing if they can resolve the temporary problems of daily life. But being satisfied with such temporary relief is like regarding the essence-less as essential. It is like completely wasting this extremely rare human existence (*manussa-attabhāva*). Likewise, in these Dhamma sermons, we must realize that whether lay or ordained, if one is engaged in this path of practice (*paṭipadā*), one can achieve

samsāric liberation through the realization of the paths and fruits (*magga-phala*). A certain Brahmin asked the Buddha: "Venerable Sir, is it the layman or the ordained one who attains these supramundane states in this Dispensation?" The Buddha declared: "That question should not be asked in that way. It is a question that must be answered with a division. For, whether one is a layman or an ordained person, if they follow the path of practice, they can realize the paths and fruits." He answered in that manner. Accordingly, we must consider that the essence to be taken from a Dhamma sermon is to achieve a peace that has not been received in our lives throughout this long samsāra. Why? In the Dhamma stories, we read, hear, and see the Buddha declaring that, in short, even the Bodhisatta himself, through his store of merit and the power of his perfections (*pāramī*), had attained the status of a Wheel-Turning Monarch (*Cakkavatti*) countless times.

Reading about the luxuries and wealth of a Wheel-Turning Monarch in those discourses (*sutta*) fills one with wonder. They describe such a vast amount of amazing pleasure and wealth in terms of the five cords of sensual pleasure (*pañca-kāma*), seemingly without end. Yet, those discourses end by showing even those to be essence-less. "All these formations (*saṅkhāra* / preparations) are impermanent (*anicca* / inconstant), monks. All of them—that Wheel-Turning Monarch is no more, his kingdoms are no more, all of them are now destroyed, subject to that impermanence (*anicca*)." In this way, the Buddha describes even things like the empire of a Wheel-Turning Monarch to show their essence-less nature. But, dear devotees, the common pattern nowadays is to preach the Dhamma by highlighting ordinary day-to-day progress—which cannot even come close to that Wheel-Turning empire—as the essence, thereby attracting a large crowd to it. This becomes something like the practice of Sañjaya. The True Dhamma will quickly disappear, and the Dispensation will quickly decline.

Therefore, on a day like today, wise devotees must reflect on such things. For, the tendency to run because others are running is always present among crowds. When there is a large crowd, when one runs, the others also run. They do not even know the reason. Later, when they look, there is nothing to be gained; it is an empty thing. All turn back. Next, they see people running to another place, and they run there too. Running and running, they go there, spending all their resources. When they go and look, there is nothing to be gained there either. Thus, they run here and there throughout their lives, as if chasing a mirage. You can know the illustrations for these stories from the things you see, hear, and read in daily life. What we are saying is just a general statement.

From all of this, we must understand something. We must have firm faith that we have the ability to highlight the essence of the Buddha's Dispensation and go a considerable distance along this path of liberation (*vimukti-magga*) in our daily lives. Whether lay or ordained, if we apply ourselves, we can reap its results even today. But we must understand that it is not something easily obtained. What is good and essential cannot be obtained easily. Growing grass is easy, but the yield is low. Farming is difficult, done with much toil, but the yield is great. We must think in this way. What do we plant in our mind-stream (*citta-santāna*)? Is it a work like growing grass? Or is it the cultivation of virtue (*sīla*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*) carried out with great effort? This is what the Buddha has said: it is like farming. He has urged us to cultivate virtues like *sīla* quickly, just as a farmer quickly does his farming when it rains.

Why does he say so? This is an extremely rare opportunity. That is why the Buddha has pointed out the word "diligence" (*appamāda*) as the most important keyword of the entire True Dhamma. Walk diligently (*appamāda*) on this path of liberation (*vimukti-magga*) and secure your release from saṃsāra. For saṃsāra is dangerous. Saṃsāra is fearful. If you do not secure a certain destiny (*niyata-gatika*) at least through a path or fruit like Stream-entry (*sotāpatti*), then, though you are living good lives now, we cannot say when our lives will end. If life is lost at some point, despite having lived well, because the store of merit that gave us this human life is exhausted, some past unwholesome kamma might surface, causing birth in an animal state, a hungry ghost (*peta*) state, or a demon state. It is because of such a dangerous saṃsāra that the Buddha regarded this obtained human existence—which even the deities hold in high esteem—as something precious and urged us to make every effort to derive the full benefit from it.

Now, in this Dhamma, physical or material goals are indeed mentioned to a certain extent. Some of you might think, "Why, in our *Maṅgala Sutta*, aren't thirty-eight blessings mentioned? Thirty-eight blessings are mentioned, aren't they? To support one's wife and children—all of these are mentioned, aren't they?" But, dear devotees, all those blessings culminate in the blessing of Nibbāna. The thirty-eighth blessing is the blessing of Nibbāna. That is why, perhaps, Nibbāna is taught as the "supreme blessing" (*paramaṃ maṅgalaṃ*) at the end. Indeed, that is the supreme blessing. Therefore, if one's wisdom is to develop, one must not just linger there, clinging to the bundle of hemp, but must make use of this human existence. Indeed, the human mind is a mind possessing an unimaginably wonderful power in this entire universe. You will easily understand this now from the feats scientists perform by developing the mind through science. But far more wonderful feats were performed in the past by the Buddhas, Paccekabuddhas, and Great Arahants who developed the power of their

perfections (*pāramī*). Because those are difficult and perhaps because their results are not glaringly visible to ordinary people, humans do not show interest in them. But we must reflect on the danger of saṃsāra. Therefore, in a Dhamma sermon, we must always remind ourselves of that word *appamāda* (diligence). Next are the objects of urgency (*saṃvega-vatthu*)—things that help to arouse energy: the danger of saṃsāra, the dangerous nature of life, birth (*jāti*), aging (*jarā*), sickness (*vyādhī*), death (*maraṇa*), and the fear of the four lower realms (*apāya-bhaya*). We must constantly contemplate these. Contemplation of death (*maraṇānussati*), and so forth. When we contemplate these, our effort increases further.

These are what we must take as the essence of this Dhamma. Through them, without falling into negligence, without being dragged into saṃsāra, and without making existence (*bhava*) something great, we aim for the cessation of existence instead of its continuation. We have run an essence-less race in this saṃsāra for so long; we have run after it. Understanding that we must bring this to an end now, we must enter the path of practice (*paṭipadā*) pointing to the heartwood shown by the Buddha, namely virtue (*sīla*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*). The true heartwood is the state of liberation (*vimukti*), which is free and detached from all. The Buddhas, entering the attainment of fruition (*phala-samāpatti*), personally experience that supreme blessing, that moment, and its real power. The greatest relief obtained from this is release from this saṃsāra. To reach that point, we must walk on the path of virtue, concentration, and wisdom; we must engage in meditation (*bhāvanā*). Generally, some people think of meditation merely as something done to cure their physical ailments, or as something done just for the sake of doing it. Today, it has become a fashion, a trend, to say, "We also meditate." But it is not something done just for the sake of saying so. Meditation means the true development of the mind. It must be done systematically. Having developed a certain concentration (*samādhi*) through tranquility (*samatha*), one must then apply one's attention—insight attention (*vipassanā-manasikāra*)—in a way that realizes the three characteristics of impermanence (*anicca*), suffering (*dukkha*), and non-self (*anattā*) in this world. Through this, when one recognizes the essence, it is natural for essence-less things to be discarded. This cannot be prevented. We know that as a tree grows, the mature and dry leaves fall. As new shoots appear at the top, leaves fall at the bottom. This cannot be prevented; it is natural. In the same way, as you devotees grow in Dhamma-knowledge, the things you previously regarded as high—those musical nights, various shows—might appear as essence-less, as mere theatrical plays (*nāḍagam*). But one should not think badly of this, wondering, "If we go on like this, won't we lose our ways of entertainment? Won't we lose our sources of

income? Won't the world become a joyless place?" Some might argue in this way. It is to such people that we sometimes refer as "promoters of the world" (*lokavaddhana*). The Buddha has urged us not to be promoters of the world. What was done for so long was the promotion of the world and the promotion of cemeteries. What remains to be done now, in this period of the arising of a Buddha (*buddhotpāda-kāla*), is to escape from this world, to escape from this entire saṃsāra.

We have the power within us to achieve that liberation. The power of perfections (*pāramī*) might be hidden. The human mind has the capacity to bring them out, even in a young child. When we say that in this Dispensation a seven-year-old child could become an Arahant, what an amazing power is demonstrated! We must constantly reflect on the timeless quality (*akālika-guṇa*) of this Dispensation—that its fruit can be reaped right here on this earth, at this very moment. Thus, when reflecting on the qualities of the Dhamma shown as visible here and now (*sanditṭhika*), timeless (*akālika*), inviting to come and see (*ehipassika*), and so forth, one develops a greater enthusiasm to walk this path. For, we are not on a fruitless journey. To whatever extent this Dhamma grows in one's mind, the results and benefits (*ānisaṃsa*) are present right there. Seeing those benefits, one is further encouraged to walk this path.

Likewise, the other side is that from those objects of urgency (*saṃvega-vatthu*), from the things happening in society, from all of them, one must draw illustrations of the painful nature of saṃsāra. Many scenes are hidden in society. It is like the setting of snares by Māra, like Māra's trap. Things that cause disillusionment with society, disillusionment with the world and society, are kept hidden. There is an attitude in the world that we should not even look at them. But the Buddha brings them to light through meditations such as the meditation on foulness (*asubha-bhāvanā*). The things shown by the Buddha may sometimes be unpleasant. Indeed, we sometimes compare them to the myrobalan fruit (*nelli*). When you first bite into a myrobalan fruit, it is indeed bitter. But it has a sweet aftertaste. That is why it is called "deathless" (*amata* / *āmalka*). Similarly, this Dhamma also has a certain bitterness at first glance. But when one practices it, the practitioner finds a wonderful taste in it. We must think in this way. One should not measure something merely because the majority of people are attracted to external polish, show, and appearance. What Sañjaya said is true: the wise in the world are few; the fools are many. But we should not merely accept that statement and remain in the same place. Even in a school, although there are various grades, everyone expects to pass. One does not remain in the same class just because one is there. Why do we sit for exams? To pass to the next class. Once there, one does not linger saying, "This is my class." Next, one sits for

another exam and goes to a higher class. It is just like that here. We need progress in this saṃsāra. Lingerin in the same place—that lingerin in the same place is what is called "the tradition of the bundle of hemp."

Therefore, recall these matters well with wisdom on a valuable day like today. Preservin a Dispensation is not something done through external things, buildings, or golden fences. Those too are necessary to arouse faith (*saddhā*) in this Dispensation. But indeed, this is like a message that goes from heart to heart. Therefore, the more we purify our hearts... Let us say the parents' hearts are pure. They walk on the path of Dhamma. They cultivate giving (*dāna*), virtue (*sīla*), meditation (*bhāvanā*), virtue (*sīla*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*). That message is then received by the child. That child, in turn, gives it to their child. In that way, the lay lineage continues. It is the same among the Sangha. When teachers and preceptors grow in these among the Sangha, it is passed on to their pupils. In that way, a Dispensation... When we speak of "this Dispensation," nowadays people think of it as if it has been deeded solely to the Sangha. But the Buddha spoke of this as something standin on four pillars, referri to the fourfold assembly of bhikkhus, bhikkhunīs, laymen (*upāsaka*), and laywomen (*upāsikā*). Thus, from the side of the devotees, our task is not to obtain wealth by hook or by crook, righteously or unrighteously, and then offer a portion of it to the Sangha to gain heavenly rebirth. What we must consider is that we too must walk on that path of Dhamma. Now, this is not something to be said at length. When we look closely at the *Maṅgala Sutta* mentioned earlier, we can see this. The lay Buddhist, startin their lay life in that manner, born in a good environment, gradually draws close to the Sangha, discusses the Dhamma, and ultimately reaches Nibbāna. Even the *Maṅgala Sutta*, which lay devotees use most, contains such a progression. From this, we can see that our life must be one that gradually moves towards progress, not one of lingerin in the same place.

So, I believe these few points will be sufficient for this meritorious assembly. You must reflect on this and decide on the path of action you should take. Indeed, what can be easily said about everyone in daily life in these times, according to their lifestyle and social conditions, is that this journey of Dhamma is not an easy one. Findin time to listen to Dhamma and practice meditation... Daily life passes through various severe economic and social pressures. But, as we said on previous occasions, we must make all of them a support to escape from this saṃsāra, to hasten this work. That is what we called "blessings in disguise." Indeed, if not for such things, some would be tempted only by luxury, lean towards unrighteousness, and end their lives without derivin any benefit from this Dhamma. But if someone understands the sufferin of life, understands the sufferin of saṃsāra, and realizes through the hardships they face in this life: "We

must have undergone such suffering for countless times, so we must find a solution to this," if one thinks so, then, even with difficulty, one will incline towards the practice of virtue, concentration, and wisdom declared by the Buddha. Once inclined, if they can open up even a small gap—spending five or ten minutes a day on meditation—as their taste, desire (*chanda*), and earnestness increase, they will realize that they have more time than before. In that way, one must make a certain sacrifice. What is called sacrifice is not wealth and resources, but time.

Indeed, what people are most hesitant to sacrifice nowadays is time. They have that much work, that much work. Likewise, there is another side—trying to do everything easily. This is due to modern science. Doing easily what we used to do with much effort. It is true that we too sometimes benefit from this indirectly. Just by turning a small key, what we previously did with great difficulty is done easily. But we must not think that the Dhamma is also like that. Often, those who had fulfilled their perfections (*pāramī*) over a very long period, like Venerable Sāriputta, understood the Dhamma in a very short time upon hearing a single verse. We should not think from this that if everyone does not attain a path or fruit from a single line of a verse, then this Dhamma is of no use. How long must those Venerable ones like Sāriputta have striven and fulfilled their perfections (*pāramī*) to attain Stream-entry from just two lines of a verse! Thinking in this way, we must realize that if we do not possess such a store of merit, we must build up that store of merit by engaging in these practices. That is why it is called a sacrifice. That time and effort—the time and effort spent on other things—must be spent on this Dhamma. For, the opportunity to do this will not be available forever. The path to Nibbāna opens up only during the period of the arising of a Buddha (*buddhotpāda-kāla*). Thinking thus, you devotees must preserve the Dispensation for yourselves. The Dispensation we must preserve is for ourselves. We say "this Dispensation preserved our nation." We express it in that way only if the Dispensation grows within each individual in that manner. Otherwise, it is merely a Dispensation brought by foreigners, existing for show, to be seen by visiting various places. That is not true progress; it is an empty, hollow thing. Therefore, as each individual walks on the path of Dhamma, if they become a noble friend (*kalyāṇa-mitta*), through that power of noble friendship, this Dispensation will grow. That is why the Buddha declared to Venerable Ānanda—as we have often reminded you—when Venerable Ānanda once stated that half of this Dispensation consists of noble friendship: "No, no, Ānanda, do not say so. The entire Dispensation is noble friendship." Therefore, everyone's goal should be to develop the store of virtues corresponding to that noble friendship and, at their own level, to treat their children at home, relatives, friends, and others in institutions with the Dhamma as far as they know, explaining it as far as they

know. If you know correctly that this is good, and not wrong views, you must explain it. By encouraging them in that way, through the journey so made, the welfare of the Dispensation is secured.

Therefore, I believe that with these few words, something necessary to remember and practice on a Poson day like today has been expressed to this meritorious assembly. You devotees have observed a certain virtue (*sīla*) according to your capacity. Virtue (*sīla*) is something highly necessary for this society—this discipline. Even looking from that perspective, we see a society where unvirtuous, dangerous crimes are committed. Having observed a valuable virtue (*sīla*) and turned to meditation, you have listened to a Dhamma sermon for about an hour at this moment. If some faith (*saddhā*), energy (*vīriya*), mindfulness (*sati*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*) arose in you through this, that itself will at some point become a faculty (*indriya*) and a power (*bala*) giving you the strength to realize the supramundane paths and fruits and find peace in the noble, supreme Nibbāna. May you aspire that, through this hearing of the Dhamma, this supportive condition (*upanissaya-sampatti*) will help you not merely in the future but in this very life, and through the association with noble friends (*kalyāṇa-mitta*), give you the strength and power to walk along the paths of Stream-entry, Once-returning, Non-returning, all the way to Arahantship. Likewise, may all beings from Avīci hell to Akaniṭṭha heaven, including the guardian deities and brahma kings, who wish to rejoice in these merits... and including our departed relatives, may they all rejoice in this store of merit accumulated today through this preaching and hearing of the Dhamma, and realize the supreme, noble Nibbāna through their aspired Bodhi! Let us aspire thus and transfer merits by reciting these verses.

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”